

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	FULL MOON	NEW MOON
2020	May 7	May 22
2021	May 26	May 11
2022	May 16	May 30
2023	May 5	May 19
2024	May 23	May 8
2025	May 12	May 27
2026	May 1, 31	May 16
2027	May 20	May 6

PLANETS

- 2020: May 22** Mercury and Venus appear less than two Moon-widths apart in the low western dusk sky.
- 2021: May 17** Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.6.
- 2021: May 29** Mercury and Venus appear less than one Moon-width apart in the low western dusk sky.
- 2022: May 29** Mars and Jupiter appear about one Moon-width apart in the eastern predawn sky.
- 2023: May 29** Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.7.
- 2024: May 9** Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.7.
- 2027: May 28** Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.6.

ECLIPSES AND TRANSITS

- 2021: May 26** A total eclipse of the Moon is visible from eastern Asia, Australia, the Pacific, and North and South America.
- 2022: May 16** A total eclipse of the Moon is visible from North and South America, Europe, and Africa.

MAY

As summer approaches, the days get longer in the Northern Hemisphere, restricting early evening observation, while in the Southern Hemisphere, the opposite is true, as the days become shorter and the nights longer. For northern observers, the Big Dipper is high up in the sky and Virgo is due south. Observers south of the equator are treated to the sight of the brilliant stars of Centaurus (the Centaur) and Crux (the Southern Cross) at their highest.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

The tip of the handle of the Big Dipper lies on the north-south meridian this month. The second star in the handle, Mizar, has a fainter companion, Alcor, which is visible to the naked eye (see p.276). The curved handle of the Big Dipper points toward orange Arcturus in Boötes, also high up. Almost due south is Spica, the brightest star in Virgo.

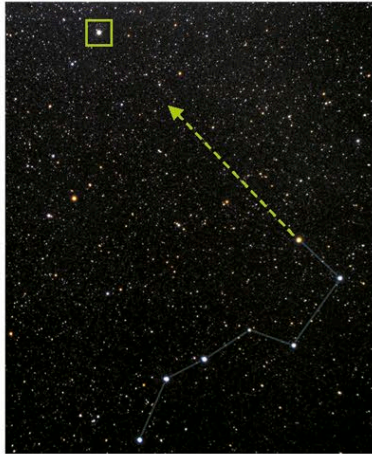
Gemini, the last of the winter constellations, begins to set in the northwest. As it departs, the stars of summer rise in the east, led by the brilliant blue-white star Vega (see p.253) in Lyra. For those observers at lower northerly latitudes, Antares and the stars of Scorpius begin to appear over the southeastern horizon.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

Two large and relatively bright galaxies are well positioned for observation in May. South of the Big Dipper's handle is the Whirlpool Galaxy (see p.315), or M51, while to the north of the handle is M101, which is larger but less prominent. On clear nights, each appears as a faint patch of light through binoculars; a telescope is needed to see their spiral structures. The fan-shaped Coma Star Cluster is well positioned, as is the Virgo Cluster of galaxies (see p.329).

METEOR SHOWER

The Eta Aquariid meteor shower is visible this month, but because the radiant lies virtually on the celestial equator, the shower is not seen well in far northerly latitudes.



FINDING THE POLE STAR
Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Ursae Majoris, in the bowl of the Big Dipper, point toward the north Pole Star, Polaris (in green box).

